

Chapter 32_1 - Ancestor Grandmother

Chu Qingqiu was indeed beautiful, but not in the way of ordinary women. She was like the moon in the sky—not only pure and bright, but also carrying the weight of long years on her shoulders. If not for her overly cold temperament, those eyes alone could have stolen countless souls.

For instance, at this moment when the two inadvertently looked at each other, Ning Fuyi actually felt that all the surrounding clamor couldn't enter her ears.

Just then, Ning Fuyi suddenly threw down the veil, blinking suspiciously. After confirming her eyes weren't malfunctioning, she pulled it away again.

The previous crimson blush was gone, replaced by sharp eyes that made Ning Fuyi shiver, but also put her at ease. She supposed it must have been the sun being too bright earlier, causing momentary eye strain.

"Let go." Chu Qingqiu gritted her teeth, then pressed down her hat and dispersed the no-longer-so-crowded crowd, striding toward the city outskirts.

"Even when I kindly try to help, it doesn't work. What a strange temperament." Ning Fuyi stood in place muttering, then shouted "Disperse, disperse!" and followed with her hands behind her back.

The two left Dongyang City first, found a secluded place and stood still, then sent a telepathic message to Qiu Yi. After she arrived, they released Bai Lin and once again ascended to the clouds.

Ning Fuyi had originally thought she would be grabbed by the collar again and had prepared herself for another strangling, but unexpectedly this time Chu Qingqiu flicked out a white silk from her sleeve, wrapping it around her waist to bring her up to the sky.

Chu Qingqiu was still quite considerate after all, Ning Fuyi thought to herself.

For the rest of the journey, Chu Qingqiu didn't speak. Only Qiu Yi occasionally opened her mouth to chat with Ning Fuyi, but every time they said less than two sentences before they would start quarreling. Finally, Chu Qingqiu could bear it no longer and simply cast a silencing spell on both of them, sealing their mouths, finally gaining a moment's peace.

Perhaps Bai Lin had slowed down again. Ning Fuyi slept two full sleeps on its back. When she woke from the second sleep, she suddenly felt light all around, with the scenery below constantly changing.

Unlike the mountains, rivers, and seas of the mortal world, the scenery below was now more magnificent and spectacular. What stretched in all directions were divine mountains and sacred sites¹, with flowers blooming eternally across the mountains and fields. Mixed with the vast clouds and mist, they formed seven-colored fog that spread far into the distance.

Bai Lin suddenly descended from the clouds, its massive body hovering in mid-air. Its tiger roar simultaneously attracted responding bird calls from all around.

Bai Lin was originally a divine beast, and now below were all divine mountains with abundant spiritual energy. Naturally, it felt like it had returned home, joyfully rushing toward the birds, its four paws dancing about.

"Bai Lin." Only when Chu Qingqiu spoke did it restrain its playful mood and properly move its four hooves, treading on wind through mid-air.

Ning Fuyi had seen such scenes before, but at that time she was already the Heaven-Destroying Demon God². Facing beautiful scenery, she thought more of destruction rather than appreciation. Now, experiencing it again as a youth, her mindset was different from the past.

She couldn't help but stand up and reach out her hand. Immediately, flocks of divine birds flew toward her, circling around her palm in formation, their seven-colored tail feathers shimmering with flowing light.

"Why can you do it?" Qiu Yi protested, also reaching her hand toward the sky.

With a "plop" sound, some passing wild goose from who knows where dropped bird droppings into her palm.

Qiu Yi: ...

Ning Fuyi couldn't help but laugh heartily. Qiu Yi was so angry she wanted to smear the bird droppings on her head, but suddenly heard Chu Qingqiu speak: "Swaggering Mountain³ has arrived."

Only then did the two look forward together.

As if unrolling a scroll painting, the divine mountains on both sides suddenly parted to either side. The smoke and clouds were blown away by the wind stirred up by Bai Lin, and the full view of Swaggering Mountain appeared before their eyes.

Qiu Yi exclaimed and stared with wide eyes.

A saying often circulated among the six realms: "Above lies Penglai⁴, below lies Swaggering Mountain," meaning that apart from these two places, there were no other such magnificent fairylands. Swaggering Mountain rose high into the clouds, with jade towers and palaces accumulated on the mountainside. Scattered trees extended from jade-white pavilions, with hundreds of flowers blooming above, their petals like stars. When the wind blew, fragrance filled the sky.

Even from such a distance, they could hear the long cries of divine birds, sounds that seemed able to strip away all distracting thoughts from the mind and move the heart.

"Look, what is that?" Qiu Yi couldn't help but call out. Ning Fuyi looked in the direction of her gaze and saw streaks of light suddenly cutting across mid-air, like falling stars, extremely spectacular.

"People," Ning Fuyi answered lazily.

Hundreds and thousands of immortal cultivators were rushing toward Swaggering Mountain together. The light points formed by sword-flying were brilliant even in daylight. Swaggering Mountain normally never allowed people to enter casually, so this scene could only be seen during the Swaggering Convention.

Getting closer and closer, the full view of the mountain became invisible. What met the eye was only the magnificent scenery of steaming clouds and rosy mists. Every blade of grass and tree was clean as if washed. At the foot of the mountain was a huge glazed mirror⁵, and those immortal cultivators were landing on the mirror one after another, putting away their spirit swords.

Bai Lin's appearance attracted everyone's attention. People rarely saw such a large white tiger and pulled their companions back, afraid of being accidentally stepped on by Bai Lin.

"Look, who is that on top?" someone exclaimed.

"Can't see clearly, but this spirit beast seems to be the divine beast White Tiger. There aren't many people in the world who can possess divine beasts, let alone the White Tiger, one of the four great divine beasts!" someone marveled. "Could this be the legendary Divine Venerable Chu Ling?"

As they spoke, Bai Lin's four feet touched the mirror surface. Only then did they see that what had seemed like a flat mirror actually rippled with huge waves. Ning Fuyi finally realized that what was beneath their feet wasn't a mirror at all, but clearly a boundless shallow pool.

The water came from who knows where, clean and transparent, with flat jade stones below reflecting a translucent blue-green color.

Chu Qingqiu seemed not to have heard their words. She gently stretched out her arms and flew down from Bai Lin with swaying robes. When her feet touched the water surface, she actually didn't get wet.

Ning Fuyi and Qiu Yi also followed her down, and with a "splash," both got soaked, awkwardly avoiding eye contact.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling! Divine Venerable Chu Ling!" Seeing Chu Qingqiu land, several people ran toward her. Leading them was a short, white-bearded old man who, along with a group of people, stood panting before Chu Qingqiu, his face full of wrinkles flushed red.

"I never expected it would really be Divine Venerable Chu Ling. Since that meeting at Eastern Bamboo Ridge⁶ five hundred years ago, the Divine Venerable still possesses such stunning beauty." The white-bearded old man excitedly puffed up his whiskers. "Everyone, my master broke through to the Great Vehicle Realm⁷ a thousand years ago thanks to the Divine Venerable's guidance. From then on, I have called the Divine Venerable my grand-master. Everyone, quickly come pay respects to the Divine Venerable."

"Greetings to Ancestor Grandmother!" The group of people in brocade robes all placed their hands on their foreheads and bowed deeply.

Ancestor Grandmother? Ning Fuyi glanced at the old man, then at Chu Qingqiu, struggling to keep her mouth closed to prevent herself from laughing out loud.

"You may rise." Chu Qingqiu was already accustomed to such scenes. She merely raised her chin slightly, not even bothering to gesture for them to rise.

"Who is this?" Ning Fuyi poked Qiu Yi and asked curiously.

Qiu Yi glared at Ning Fuyi disdainfully and said haughtily: "That's Elder Song Xiang⁸ of Sky Pivot Sword Sect⁹. See? Even an elder of the first great sect must be respectful to my master."

"Tch." Ning Fuyi curled her lips.

Elder Song Xiang over there was still trying every way to chat with his "Ancestor Grandmother" when suddenly a great wind arose overhead, nearly knocking Ning Fuyi off her feet. She covered her face and looked up at the sky.

Seven-colored auspicious clouds were shattered by a huge black dragon. The black dragon rolled in the sky, then spread its four claws and dove toward the ground. With another splash of water, a black dragon as large as a small mountain landed in the water, prostrating on the ground.

Its abyssal maw opened wide, and a bright red forked tongue emerged. Ning Fuyi thought it was hungry and wanted to eat a person or two for fun, but unexpectedly a person appeared on the tip of its tongue, followed by more people in black robes crawling out of the snake's mouth and sliding down the tongue to the ground.

This scene was quite bizarre. Ning Fuyi raised her eyebrows and watched for a long time before recognizing which sect these disciples belonged to.

Ghost Sight Sect¹⁰, commonly called "Ghost's Sorrow"—their cultivation methods perfectly matched the literal meaning of their sect name. There wasn't a ghost that wouldn't feel sorrow upon seeing them. Unlike other orthodox sects that always liked to nestle in various immortal mountains and spiritual peaks, this sect built their headquarters outside the ruins of an ancient battlefield where many gods had fallen, claiming to borrow divine power but actually absorbing yin energy¹¹.

The reason they could still be ranked among the six great sects despite such cultivation methods was because this approach was indeed effective. Ghost Sight Sect's overall strength could rank second among the six great sects. Although their appearance was often mistaken for demons, since they dealt with the dead rather than the living, they were still considered a prestigious orthodox sect.

The black dragon retracted its tongue, retreated, and disappeared, leaving the Ghost Sight Sect's master and disciples in a long line. Without looking at anyone else, they walked stiffly toward Swaggering Mountain. People made way for them wherever they passed, not daring to get too close.

Just as Ghost Sight Sect left, there was another commotion behind them. Ning Fuyi looked up again and saw a mass of black things flying from somewhere, forming a butterfly shape in the sky with over a dozen people standing on it. Whether male or female, all were charming and alluring in myriad ways. At the same time, a strange fragrance drifted over. Those who smelled it had their vision blur and showed intoxicated expressions.

Ning Fuyi covered her nose with her sleeve before the strange fragrance entered her body, watching from the sidelines as Qiu Yi's face showed a foolish smile and her body involuntarily moved forward.

Fortunately, Chu Qingqiu coughed, and Qiu Yi immediately awakened.

"I was almost bewitched by them." Qiu Yi fearfully covered her nose. "This Bliss Sect¹² is really bold, daring to release strange fragrances in broad daylight."

The butterfly-shaped thing scattered in mid-air, revealing that they were indeed butterflies. For a moment, the sky was full of butterflies flapping colorful wings. Those men and women gracefully descended from the butterflies. The leading woman was the most beautiful, with flowers adorning her entire body, her sleeves hung with blooming flowers. Her feet moved quickly, landing in front of Chu Qingqiu.

Her figure looked graceful, but she nearly knocked Elder Song Xiang down with her bottom.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling." The woman's eyes were full of emotion as she smiled behind her hand, placing her other hand on Chu Qingqiu's wrist, only to be subtly avoided by Chu Qingqiu.

"Who is this person again?" Ning Fuyi immediately developed a gossipy interest and walked to Qiu Yi's side to ask.

"Why do you have so many questions?" Qiu Yi gave her an unfriendly look. "This is the sect master of Bliss Sect, named Li Han Dan¹³. Others call her Fairy Han Dan."

She spoke with great disdain, as if she extremely disliked this Bliss Sect master.

Ning Fuyi originally wanted to ask why, but when she looked at Chu Qingqiu again, she understood. So she crossed her arms over her chest and cheerfully watched the excitement.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling, we haven't seen each other for a hundred years. I never expected Divine Venerable Chu Ling to still be so stunningly beautiful. It truly makes my heart flutter." Fairy Han Dan curved her emotional eyes. She claimed to be making small talk, but her whole person was almost burrowing into Chu Qingqiu's embrace.

Chu Qingqiu's face had turned somewhat green. She flicked her sleeve to create a blast of air, pushing the woman in front of her away, suppressing her anger as she said: "Yes, it has been many years."

Although Chu Qingqiu had a bad personality, she was indeed popular. Don't look at how she stayed shut away in the mountains cultivating all day—every time she appeared, she could attract so many admirers. Ning Fuyi couldn't help but sigh.

But before she could take out some snacks to watch the show, another person came down from Swaggering Mountain. This person truly had the bearing of an orthodox sect—wearing silver robes and fur, a lotus crown on his head, holding a fine steel heavy sword, swift as wind. Upon seeing Chu Qingqiu, he warmly bowed.

Ning Fuyi actually recognized this person—Tang Wen Shu¹⁴, the sect master of Sky Pivot Sword Sect, with extremely high cultivation, famous for his unpredictable swordsmanship. In her previous life, after Ning Fuyi became a demon, she fought him for three days and nights, subduing him under her Emei Thorns¹⁵, so her impression was deep.

When Fairy Han Dan saw him coming, she immediately returned to normal, standing dignifiedly and gracefully bowing to him, though her eyes still occasionally glanced toward Chu Qingqiu.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling." Tang Wen Shu put away his heavy sword and cupped his fists. "Not knowing of the Divine Venerable's arrival, this humble one failed to welcome you properly."

"Sect Master Tang." Chu Qingqiu returned his courtesy.

"I heard that the Divine Venerable has now taken over Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate¹⁶, so..."

"They're slower and will probably arrive later." Chu Qingqiu replied.

Tang Wen Shu smiled and made a gesture of invitation: "Then please, both sect masters, move to rest first. The Holy Maiden of Swaggering Mountain¹⁷ who manages this place is unwell today and cannot receive everyone, so she has entrusted this matter to me."

"Elder Song Xiang, please trouble yourself to take the two sect masters to rest."

Chu Qingqiu nodded and walked ahead first. Fairy Han Dan held her wrist with flowing eyes, and after a while, gracefully followed.

Qiu Yi naturally went with Chu Qingqiu. Ning Fuyi, not knowing where to go alone, also started to lift her feet, but was unexpectedly stopped by Tang Wen Shu's outstretched hand.

She warily stepped back and stared at the man with furrowed brows.

"Young fairy friend, don't be afraid." Tang Wen Shu smiled warmly. "May I ask if you are the daughter of Condensing Heaven Sect Master, Ning Fuyi?"

Ning Fuyi was stunned, not expecting anyone to recognize her. She nodded and lowered her head to bow, but was supported by him.

"Ning Fuyi..." Tears seemed to glisten in his eyes as he softly repeated this name, making Ning Fuyi break out in goosebumps.

"Don't be afraid. It's just that you bear seven parts resemblance to Condensing Heaven Sect Master, so I could recognize you at a glance." Tang Wen Shu withdrew his hands, but his gaze remained fixed on Ning Fuyi without moving away.

"About your mother's matter..." Tang Wen Shu sighed heavily. "When I heard about it, she had already been buried. I didn't even have the chance to see her off. It's truly regrettable."

As he spoke, his eyes actually reddened, and he took out a pink stone from his chest, his expression tender: "This item was given to me by Condensing Heaven Sect Master two thousand years ago. I have treasured it until now."

Ning Fuyi looked at his expression suspiciously. That sadness didn't seem fake. Could this person also be an old friend of Ning Changfeng¹⁸?

She did know that Ning Changfeng was someone who liked to roam freely and act chivalrously, so she knew countless people. She just didn't know who exactly were her old acquaintances.

In all those previous years, she had only ever seen Chu Qingqiu.

"Oh, my condolences." Ning Fuyi's lips twitched.

Tang Wen Shu exhaled, wiped away tears with his sleeve, and shook his head: "I shouldn't be saying these things to you at such a time. You're tired from the journey. I'll have someone take you to rest right away."

"Someone come." He said quietly, and a Sky Pivot Sword Sect disciple quickly approached.

"Take the young sect master to rest," Tang Wen Shu said.

Ning Fuyi politely bid him farewell and followed the short disciple into the air. She had originally thought that not being able to sword-fly would cause some trouble, but after leaping up, she discovered that her body was incredibly light, like a feather in the wind, easily soaring a hundred meters.

Worthy of being a sacred site, she thought with secret delight.

The two landed on the mountainside. This place looked magnificent from afar with steaming clouds and rosy mists, but once inside, it was even more beautiful and fantastic. The walking paths were all made of jade stone, with small bridges and flowing water everywhere. The water was as brilliant as scattered gold. Up close, the scenery was exquisite and elegant; from afar, layers of seven-colored auspicious clouds swirled around, with various divine mountains interspersed among them. Occasionally, one could see guardian divine beasts Blue Luan¹⁹ flying across the sky, inspiring awe.

The short disciple led her for a while, then pointed to a three-story pavilion with a crystal roof ahead, politely saying: "Young Sect Master, this is where the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate disciples are housed. Please go in and rest. This humble one takes his leave."

Ning Fuyi thanked him, then suddenly remembered something and hurriedly stopped him, asking with a smile: "Do you know where the sect masters and elders are staying?"

"The masters of the six great sects are all housed in the Peach Blossom Garden²⁰, which is over there." The disciple pointed with his hand. Ning Fuyi turned back to look and saw that behind the layered pavilions was a secluded place with a sea of pink misty flowers, among which scattered towers could be vaguely seen.

"The other smaller sects are generally housed down the mountain." The disciple pointed again to the layered eaves below the mountain.

"Good, thank you." After Ning Fuyi finished speaking, she turned and walked into the pavilion. The pavilion looked magnificent from the outside, but inside it was even more extraordinary. Each room had fan-shaped windows, and outside the windows, one could see the vast sea of clouds.

How much better this was than the poor Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, Ning Fuyi marveled as she randomly chose a room with a good view and lay down.

Most gratifying was that the room actually had various fruits and pastries prepared. Though there was no meat, it was enough to fill one's stomach, suitable for someone like her who hadn't achieved fasting yet.

The nearby pavilions were all residences for disciples of the six great sects, so there were always waves of people walking toward this area. Occasionally there was noise, but most of the time one could only hear bird songs from the mountains, creating a peaceful mood perfect for cultivation.

With nothing else to do, Ning Fuyi sat down to meditate and practice her pitiful cultivation. The spiritual energy here was indeed abundant—compared to Cloud Ascension Mountain, her cultivation speed was much faster.

So Ning Fuyi sat and sat until she entered a trance. When she opened her eyes refreshed, the sky had already darkened.

The last trace of red sunset hung on the horizon, and lights lit up everywhere, illuminating hundreds of pavilions.

She admired her hands for a while, then jumped down from the bed and opened the door. She saw that the surrounding rooms were also occupied. The other disciples of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate had arrived at some point. Having flown for two full days, they were now sleeping like the dead.

On a dark and windy night—perfect for searching for demonic artifacts. Without hesitation, Ning Fuyi raised her hand to create a barrier to seal her aura, then pulled out the formation diagram she had drawn that day from her pouch, spread it on the ground, and channeled her immortal power into it.

Brilliant golden light lit up again. Ning Fuyi's divine consciousness sank into unfamiliar scenery—a place so clean it seemed to have nothing, with the ground reflecting human figures and surroundings like a horizon with no visible end.

Ning Fuyi controlled her divine consciousness to continue forward. Black clouds scattered, and a tall tower suddenly appeared before her. The tower almost reached the sky, with its top nowhere to be seen, only a point of light visible at the tower's peak.

The next instant, she returned to reality. Though she had only seen it for a moment, she knew where the Emei Thorns were hidden.

Divine Meteor²¹, a branch of Swaggering Mountain, was the old site where a True God²² had fallen, and also a forbidden land that no one had been able to set foot in for tens of thousands of years.

In her previous life, Ning Fuyi had broken in and nearly succeeded, but at the last moment was discovered by the Holy Maiden of Swaggering Mountain, who chased her out of Swaggering Mountain with a flaming spear.

Ning Fuyi stared out the window with deep eyes for a while, then silently put away the formation diagram, removed the barrier, and leaped out of the pavilion.

Since she, Ning Fuyi, knew where the Emei Thorns were, there was no reason not to seize them.

Swaggering Mountain originally housed only the Holy Maiden of Swaggering Mountain and a few small immortal attendants, with no guards. So Ning Fuyi walked through the night without encountering anyone. She almost effortlessly stepped on treetops, heading toward Divine Meteor.

But just as she was about to approach the branch peak, she suddenly detected a trace of immortal power from the dark tree shadows beneath her feet. She quickly concealed her aura and dropped into the dense branches.

Two people passed in front of her. Fortunately, she was still quite far away, so they didn't notice her.

Those two had trailing hems and appeared to be women. One had a graceful and alluring figure. Through the dim skylight, she could determine that this was the Bliss Sect master from the daytime, Fairy Han Dan.

"Sect Master, are we really going to do this? This is the Swaggering Convention. If something goes wrong, we'll be embarrassing ourselves in front of the six great sects."

"Embarrassing? When has this Li Han Dan ever feared such a thing? Besides, everyone knows how our Bliss Sect cultivates. With our strong abilities, who dares say anything?" Fairy Han Dan swayed her body and sneered.

"Moreover, how many years does this sect master get to see her once? If I don't seize this opportunity, I'm afraid I'll never see her again." Fairy Han Dan lowered her voice, her tone becoming seductive. "I've been infatuated with her for a thousand years. To make me give up is absolutely impossible."

"Then will our method work?"

"Why wouldn't it? Whether male or female, our Bliss Sect's specialty is seduction arts. Otherwise, how could we have cultivated to our current level?" Li Han Dan laughed. "Even if a True God were resurrected, they couldn't resist my 'Cold Plum Surpassing Snow'²³ fragrance."

Ning Fuyi suddenly covered her ears after hearing these words. The most taboo thing in the martial world was learning other people's secrets, especially those of a sect master. She didn't want to invite trouble, so she turned to quietly escape.

However, just before leaving, a familiar name suddenly drifted into her ears. Ning Fuyi's heart strings immediately tightened, and she stopped in place, shocked.

"Chu Qingqiu—I must have her tonight." She heard Li Han Dan laugh charmingly.

Footnotes:

1. **Divine mountains and sacred sites (神山神址)** - Holy places where immortals and gods reside or once lived
2. **Heaven-Destroying Demon God (诛天神魔)** - Ning Fuyi's title in her previous life when she became a demon
3. **Swaggering Mountain (招摇山)** - The host location for the martial arts convention
4. **Penglai (蓬莱)** - A legendary mystical island in Chinese mythology, home to immortals
5. **Glazed mirror (琉璃镜)** - What appeared to be a mirror but was actually a shallow pool
6. **Eastern Bamboo Ridge (东篁岭)** - A location where they previously met
7. **Great Vehicle Realm (大乘)** - One of the higher cultivation realms
8. **Song Xiang (松香)** - Literally means "Pine Fragrance"
9. **Sky Pivot Sword Sect (天玑剑宗)** - One of the six great sects, literally means "Sky Pivot/Pole Star Sword Sect"
10. **Ghost Sight Sect (鬼见宗)** - A sect that cultivates using death/yin energy, literally "Ghost Sees Sect"
11. **Yin energy (阴气)** - Negative/dark spiritual energy associated with death and ghosts
12. **Bliss Sect (合欢门)** - A sect that uses seduction techniques, literally "Joyful Union Gate"
13. **Li Han Dan (李萼菖)** - The Bliss Sect master, with "Han Dan" being a poetic name for lotus
14. **Tang Wen Shu (唐温书)** - Sky Pivot Sword Sect master, literally "Tang Warm Books"
15. **Emei Thorns (峨眉刺)** - The demonic weapon Ning Fuyi seeks to retrieve
16. **Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门)** - Ning Fuyi's sect
17. **Holy Maiden of Swaggering Mountain (招摇圣女)** - The leader/guardian of Swaggering Mountain
18. **Ning Changfeng (宁长风)** - Ning Fuyi's adoptive mother and former sect master
19. **Blue Luan (青鸾)** - A mythical bird, often depicted as a divine beast
20. **Peach Blossom Garden (桃花源)** - The area where sect masters are housed
21. **Divine Meteor (神陨)** - The forbidden area where the Emei Thorns are hidden
22. **True God (真神)** - The highest level of divine being
23. **Cold Plum Surpassing Snow (寒梅胜雪)** - The name of Li Han Dan's seduction technique